

Designing a Session Tracker People Keep Using

The dashboard is not the product. The first five seconds are. For a Pandan-style app that tracks focus sessions, the thing that decides success is not how pretty the analytics look — it's whether starting a session costs one tap and whether the app gives the user a reason to come back tomorrow. This brief covers the dashboard layout, the UX principles that reduce friction, the engagement mechanics that actually retain users (with real platform data), and a categorization model that goes well beyond "which app were you in."

1 tap To start a session Every extra step loses users	+34% Longer streaks with social 5.69 vs 4.25 days avg	+48% Streak length with freezes 17.2 vs 11.6 days past day 7	0.9% Return after short break Week one is make- or-break
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I. What the Dashboard Should Show

1. Lead with today, not
the archive

HIERARCHY

The single most prominent element is the current or most-recent session — everything else is supporting context. Time-tracking dashboards fail when they present active timers, daily totals, streaks, project breakdowns, and history with equal weight. The screen becomes a wall of numbers.

- **Hero zone:** a big start button plus today's focused time and current streak. This answers "what now?" and "am I on track today?" instantly.
- **Mid zone:** a weekly focus rhythm — a bar chart or heatmap of sessions per day. This answers "how's my week?"
- **Quiet zone:** category breakdown, longest session, all-time stats. Accessible, visually restrained, never competing for attention.

2. The weekly rhythm chart

A day-by-day view of focused minutes is the most useful single visual — it shows momentum, reveals peak days, and makes a broken streak feel visible before it happens.

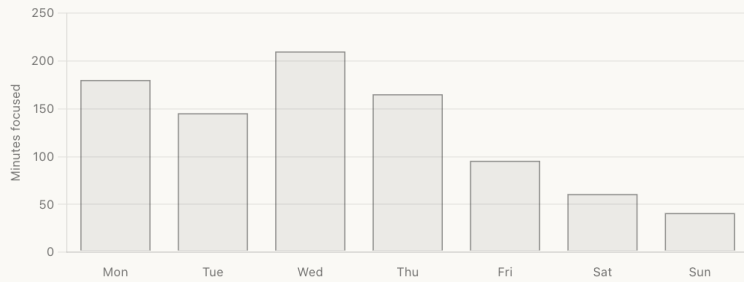


Fig. 1 — Example weekly focus rhythm. Users read shape, not exact values, so keep it glanceable.

3. Where the time actually went

A category breakdown is the payoff of tracking — it turns "I worked 6 hours" into "4 hours of deep work, 90 minutes of meetings, 30 minutes leaking to distraction." Keep it to a handful of slices; more than 6 is noise.



Fig. 2 — Example session breakdown by category. Slices should map to how the user thinks about their day.

4. The four numbers that matter

METRICS

Resist the urge to show everything. Four live stats carry a session dashboard.

- Today's focused time — the "did I show up" number.
- Current streak — the "don't break the chain" number.
- Sessions completed (today / this week) — a count of wins.
- Best focus window — e.g. "you focus best 9–11am," a personalized insight that no spreadsheet gives you.

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Users don't have to waste time every day managing the app that is supposed to help them spend their time more efficiently.

Eleken, on designing the Tymewise time tracker

II. Make Tracking Effortless

5. One click, or they stop tracking

CORE RULE

Every extra step between the user and a running session leaks users. Behavioral research is blunt here: small barriers dramatically reduce the likelihood of a behavior. When starting a session means "open app → pick project → name task → set category → start," people skip it "just this once" — and that becomes the norm.

- Starting, pausing, and switching a session should each take one or two taps, from the main screen.
- The timer should stay visible in a persistent header on every screen, not buried in a tab.
- Let users start first and categorize later. Force a category up front and you add friction at the worst moment.

6. Automatic capture beats manual memory

ACCURACY

The most reliable session data is the data the user never had to enter. Self-reported time estimates are off by 20–40%. Tools like Rize interpret app usage, browser tabs, and calendar events to auto-detect focus, meeting, and break sessions — the entries are simply there when the user looks.

- Detect a session automatically (sustained activity in an app), then let the user confirm or re-label with one tap.
- Auto-categorize using rules the user can teach: "when I'm in Figma, that's design work."
- Recover forgotten stops gracefully — fixing a runaway timer must be painless, not a data-integrity lecture.

7. Smart defaults and quick reviews

Pre-fill from history; let the user tidy in bulk later. Pin the 3–7 most-used session types on the home screen for true one-tap starts. Pull recent projects, typical durations, and last-used category as defaults — data-driven defaults can speed entry 20–35%.

- Offer a 30-second end-of-day review to confirm/relabel today's auto-captured sessions.
- Keep the taxonomy small. Complex category trees create friction; you can always add detail later, but you can't recover data that was never captured because the flow felt heavy.

III. Make It Engaging — and Prove It Works

8. Streaks, freezes, and the Friday cliff

Platform data from a gamification provider (1M+ users) shows freeze mechanics keep users on-streak far longer, and that productivity apps hemorrhage streaks on Fridays when work structure disappears.

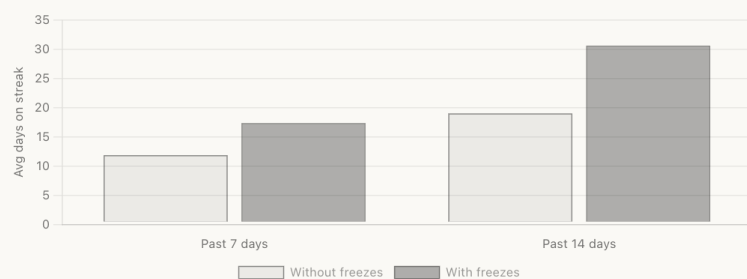


Fig. 3 — Average days on-streak past the 7-day mark, with vs. without a freeze / grace-day mechanic. Source: Trophy platform data.

9. Loss aversion needs something worth losing

FOREST MODEL

A number resetting feels minor. A living thing dying feels worse. Forest turns a focus session into a tree that grows while you stay on task and dies if you leave — the loss aversion is only as strong as the perceived value of what's at stake. For Pandan, invest in what the streak *represents*: a growing garden, a building, an evolving visual, not just a counter.

- Give the user a persistent artifact that accumulates across sessions and is visibly diminished by a lapse.
- Consider a prosocial hook (Forest funds real tree-planting) — it converts private focus into something that feels like it matters.

10. Reward the right thing, or users game it

WARNING

Productivity is the category most vulnerable to the proxy-metric problem. Todoist's Karma rewards task completion regardless of importance, so the fastest path to a high score is doing many trivial tasks. A session tracker has the same trap: reward raw session count and users start logging junk sessions.

- Weight deep, uninterrupted focus blocks more heavily than a pile of two-minute sessions.
- Surface a quality signal — context-switches per session, or completed vs. abandoned — not just duration.

11. Accountability beats competition here

SOCIAL

For personal-goal behavior, a partner outperforms a leaderboard. Apps with social streak features average 5.69 days on-streak vs. 4.25 without — a 34% lift. But leaderboards create competition while an accountability partner creates obligation, and obligation retains better for private, professional goals.

- Offer an optional focus buddy or shared progress view over a public ranking.
- Time your re-engagement: send a Thursday nudge *before* the Friday risk window, and a gentle Sunday "start fresh" for anyone who lapsed.

12. Protect week one above all

Only ~0.9% of users who lose a 2–3 day streak ever come back to start a new one. The first week decides whether a habit forms or the user churns. Front-load acknowledgement: celebrate the first session, day 3, day 5, day 7. Offer streak freezes early so a single bad day doesn't feel like total failure — and avoid harsh punishment mechanics, which make struggling users quit rather than restart.

IV. How to Categorize Sessions

13. Beyond "which app" — five useful lenses

YOUR QUESTION

App/activity is only the first axis. The insight users actually want comes from layering several lightweight dimensions. You asked "categories based on the user's apps and activities... based on the user's what?" — here are the dimensions worth capturing:

14. The categorization model

DIMENSION	EXAMPLE VALUES	WHY IT MATTERS
App / activity	Figma, VS Code, Docs, Zoom	Auto-detected; the raw signal behind everything else.
Work type	Deep work, meeting, admin, learning, break	The most useful lens — separates focus from overhead.
Project / client	Client A, side project, thesis	Answers "where did my week go" and enables billing.
Intent / goal	Ship feature, study for exam, write	Ties a session to why it happened, not just what app.
Energy / focus quality	Deep vs. shallow, interrupted vs. clean	Reveals when the user does their best work.
Time context	Morning / afternoon, weekday / weekend	Powers "you focus best 9–11am" style insights.

15. Auto-derive, don't ask

Most of these dimensions can be inferred, not typed. App/activity, time context, and focus quality (via context-switching) are all detectable automatically. Only work type and intent may need a one-tap confirmation. The design goal: the user teaches the rules once, then the app categorizes silently and asks only when it's genuinely unsure.

- Start with 4–5 work-type buckets — deep work, meetings, admin, learning, break — since that split delivers the most insight for the least friction.
- Let power users add project/intent tags; keep them optional so casual users are never blocked.

V. What To Build First

16. The minimum lovable version

PRIORITY

Ship the loop before the analytics. A session tracker earns its place with a tight start → focus → reward cycle, not a rich dashboard on day one.

- **Must-have:** one-tap start/pause/stop, today's focused time, current streak, one weekly chart, 4–5 auto-suggested categories.
- **Fast follow:** streak freezes, early-milestone celebrations, a growing visual artifact, "your best focus window" insight.
- **Later:** automatic session detection, teachable categorization rules, optional focus buddy, calendar integration.

